

secrecy is maintained as far as possible. That is crucial for me if I am to get the best price for my clients,' he said.

I felt a twinge of irritation. Of course I knew the importance of secrecy in this business. After all, I had now been in the market for nearly eighteen months. As though he was reading my thoughts from my expression, Govindbhai suddenly said, 'Lala, I am aware that you know all this. Still, I thought it would be worth your while to know how particular I am about the confidentiality of my clients' trades. They pay me the best brokerage, and I owe it to them to get the best possible rates. I do not tolerate indiscretion. If I hear you have been indiscreet about my trades, I will not demand any explanation. I have enough friends who keep me informed about what is happening in the market. Dealers who betray me find it hard to get another job with a decent broker. I hope you get the drift.'

I nodded.

'What were you getting paid?'

'10,000 plus a share of my jobbing profits.'

'I will match that. Just ensure that your jobbing trades are not based on the orders we get.'

'I will keep that in mind. Do I start today?'

'No. Go back and think over what I have said. Take my offer only if you feel you can abide by my terms. Let me be frank, I can be a very demanding boss.'

'You will find me equal to the task.'

'I like your confidence. Still, I insist you give it a thought.'

I did not have much to think about. I was quite impressed with Govindbhai. I joined him the following day, and it was to be the beginning of an enduring protégé-mentor relationship. Until this time I had been a self-taught trader. But there were plenty of gaps in my learning and I sorely lacked a good tutor. My association with Govindbhai would gradually fill those gaps.

I soon got to know that one of the reasons for Govindbhai's success was the strength of the relationships he had forged over the years, even though he was very choosy about them.

'It is easy to initiate a relationship, but the challenge is to sustain it, and you can never say which one will turn out to be helpful in a crisis,' he once told me.